

Considering How the Arts Contribute to the Teaching and Learning of Pupils with Severe and Profound Learning Difficulties

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Children with Disabilities: Theory, Politics and Experience

Many people with severe and profound learning difficulties (PMLD) throughout time have utilised their unique perspectives of the world to learn through artistic exploration, with evidence that *“Michelangelo suffered from Asperger’s disorder, or high-functioning autism”* (Wiszniowska-Majchrzyk and Majchrzyk, 2014, p.74) and the painter Van Gogh, who lived with various mental illnesses in his life (Wolf, 2001). It can be said that in education, the arts and art therapies can contribute to how we educate children with PMLD, as well as in the way they learn life skills and communication (Edwards et al. 2020). This essay critically discusses the use of three different forms of artistic expression to aid learning for children with PMLD; music, theatre and visual arts (such as painting, crafting and sculpting). These mediums can all be used to *“enhance learning experiences for children with disabilities”* (Saldaña 2016, p.94) meaning that these children are able to express how they feel when they might normally struggle, and to become more confident interacting socially, among many other benefits. However, limitations can also be discussed in terms of little research having been conducted, which makes it difficult to fully understand how effective teaching and learning through the arts for children with PMLD is. In addition, while the activities can provide immense sensory stimulation, due to communication barriers some children may experience in expressing their thoughts and emotions it can be difficult to interpret the true benefit of the practice. Nevertheless, overwhelmingly the practice has been deemed positive and a way to create unique learning opportunities for children with PMLD.

Music

Children with PMLD may have many difficulties in their ability to move, speak and communicate their feelings and thoughts (Meadows, 1997). Therefore, one way that the arts can be used as a therapy for these children to help them learn, and as a way of *“fulfilling a child’s basic needs”* (Meadows,

1997, p.4) is to use music, and more specifically music therapy. This type of therapy isn't new, having been used in some way for many centuries (Hadley et al., 2001). Today it can be interpreted as “*a systematic process of intervention wherein the therapist helps the client...using music experiences and the relationships that develop through them as dynamic forces of change*” (Bruscia, 1998a, p.20 cited in Aigen, 2013, p.22). We can understand music therapy as having various goals, such as aiming to provide children who have a learning difficulty with an outlet for expression, allowing them to take ownership of their actions through making music, connecting with the therapist which enhances social interaction and to improve fine motor skills such as holding instruments and moving their body to make various sounds (Meadows, 1997). Moreover, Stephenson (2006) also discusses the way in which music can be used as a form of therapy to help children with disabilities explore and develop physical motor skills and to provide mental stimulation while developing self-expression.

In addition, many positive and beneficial aspects of using music to teach and support students with PMLD have been presented. The effectiveness of music therapy in supporting children with PMLD was demonstrated in the case study by Perry (2003) which explored the use of improvisational music therapy using instruments such as piano and guitar on severely and profoundly disabled children. Most of the children in the study had been diagnosed with cerebral palsy which affects motor skills, vision and visual attention and some others had been diagnosed with a genetic condition which causes blindness and hearing loss (Perry, 2003).

The study's results displayed that the children could begin to respond and mimic the therapists' actions using the instruments, ‘replying’ to the therapist through music by taking turns when pauses were created. This helped the children to understand when to interact with another person in response to a form of communication such as percussion from a drum. In addition, Johnels et al. (2023) review of a variety of different studies conducted from 2003 to 2020 using observation of videos from music

therapy sessions found that almost 50% of the children showed some responsiveness to the music therapist and interacted with them, conveying a benefit of the practice and use of music. Another benefit of music therapy is the improvement of reading skills of children with intellectual disabilities, which was evidenced by Abdullahi Babatunde., et.al (2022) in the systematic review of articles relating to music therapy. Here the authors argue that the music therapy use investigated had a “*a statistically significant main effect on pupils' reading skills with intellectual disability*” (Jacob and Pillay, 2021, cited in Abdullahi Babatunde., et.al, 2022, p.7), demonstrating one area of teaching and learning utilising the arts where students with an intellectual disability developed increased proficiency in reading. Additionally, another study by Rushton and Kosyvaki (2020) found that musical play had a positive effect on children's physical and emotional reactions in play. Overall, this evidence displays the advantage of using music therapy in helping PMLD children to communicate, reciprocate actions, express emotions and develop motor skills.

Conversely, while music therapy use for children with PMLD is overwhelmingly positive, some limitations have been observed. Some research has displayed the ineffectiveness of the use of music to help these children learn. Pickard (2020) critically disputed the use of music therapy, claiming that the therapy may simply be a way of encouraging a certain set of behaviours in a medical framework, therefore practicing a discouragement of behaviours deemed as unproductive and problematic in society. Signaling the actions and behaviours of children with PMLD as ‘wrong’ and in need of correcting through music therapy could be seen as controversial and unhelpful in aiding these children's basic needs. In addition to this, researchers Thompson and McFerran (2015) studied the effectiveness of music therapy, where a range of musical instruments was introduced to the children for them to play with or listen to. Their names were also embedded into songs sung and the music was played in a rhythmical beat. They compared using music to using play with a child's favourite toy. The researchers ultimately found that “*music therapy was no more effective in increasing the*

number of communicative acts of the participants than the same therapist playing with a favourite toy” (p.8), conveying that music may not be an effective alternative learning aid to the more traditional approach, learning through playing with toys. Some studies such as one conducted by Kossyvaki and Curran (2020), also describe a lack of clarity in results as it can be hard to measure effectiveness when the participants movements are so slight and can be hard to distinguish an outcome (a movement, vocalisation or interaction) that can be solely accredited to music therapy. With these limitations in mind, we can still understand the immensely positive outcomes that music has for children with PMLD, acting as a personalised method of teaching which suits them best.

Theatre

According to Goodley and Runswick-Cole (2011), theatre can be experienced, enjoyed and used in teaching and learning for children with PMLD, with the theatre company *Oily Cart* being at the forefront of this initiative. The company provides “*multi-sensory and inter-active productions*” (p.79) for PMLD children, with the actors being both disabled and non-disabled. One area of progress the researchers studied through observation of the *Oily Cart* performances was the individual development of the children, with one child who was sensitive to sound having by the end of the performance removed his ear defenders, feeling more comfortable listening to the performance without them. Another example given was when a child rocked in time with the music she was listening to during the performance, displaying attention to rhythm and an evolution of movement (Goodley and Runswick-Cole, 2011). Brigg (2013) also assesses the *oily cart* productions, claiming they provide a unique multisensory experience for the PMLD audience. They provide full interaction with the audience by allowing children to touch the performative props, listen to songs and music and experience a variety of lighting and special effects. This emphasises the central need of immersive stimuli for PMLD children as an aid to their overall wellbeing and as a method for accessing a sense of self through full emersion within theatre.

Additionally, Booker and Booker (2011) highlight the effectiveness of developmental drama (or *dramatherapy*), the aim of which is to help validate expression and communication towards others in any form and develop imagination through stimulating sensory experiences. Developmental drama draws on the theory of the zone of proximal development (Vygotsky, 1978, cited in Booker and Booker, 2011) which facilitates independent action or actions which can be assisted by others such as a therapist or primary caregiver. In this way theatre can be used to build on a person's preexisting abilities and develop a variety of social, emotional and physical skills with the aid of another. Eventually this support and encouragement creates developmental growth in the child which improves overtime and allows them to feel more independent and in control of their bodies, known as scaffolding (Pea, 2004). These various usages of theatre represent one way in which the arts have been able to contribute to the learning and teaching of children with PMLD.

Moreover, Masud et al. (2013) discusses the exclusion of disabled children from the arts and theatre. They emphasis how opportunities for children with PMLD within the performing arts is limited and “*dominated by able bodied artists*” (p.6). They examine the misconception in society that a lack of ability in one area due to an impairment means disabled children are unable to enjoy or engage with performance and theatre productions. However, there are many ways in which disabled children can learn from and participate in theatre and there are many benefits too, including empowering an individual to be confident, building social connections and stimulating imagination (Matarazzo, 1997, cited in Goodley and Runswick-Cole, 2011).

In contrast, some limitations for the use of theatre and dramatherapy are apparent. Firstly, a lack of evidence-based research on the practice of dramatherapy means that this area of teaching is not fully understood which could create misunderstandings and misuse. Additionally, according to Milward and Seymour (2023) it can be hard for children to “*be truly heard*” (p.53) during drama therapy sessions as the therapist's involvement in assisting the children may become dominating. It can therefore be hard to differentiate between what the child is trying to communicate themselves and

what is being communicated for them by others. This displays that while dramatherapy use for children with PMLD can be somewhat effective in improving self-expression and aiding emotional and physical wellbeing, it can be difficult to pinpoint the overall success of its use due to the lack of research and the chance of the children being misunderstood when participating.

The visual arts

Moreover, another area of the arts that may help children with PMLD learn, experience sensory stimulation and self-expression is using visual arts such as painting, drawing, craftmaking and sculpting. Art therapy is a key way to develop a nonverbal form of communication and can help to *“increase creativity and emotional growth of children”* (Rahmani and Rahmani, 2014, p.4). According to Peter (2015), as the national curriculum was introduced to schools in the UK, people began to also think about the creation of the arts curriculum in special education. Peter (2015) goes on to express that one way of expanding a learner's creative output is to help them understand how their choices impact others and how decisions they make affect what they are working on. For instance, the learner can be helped to understand how a brush stroke on paper using paint will create a shape on the page. By recognising this, the author believes that a child with PMLD's capability and development will improve, becoming more self-aware and in control of how their actions affect the world around them. Wright (2023) concurs with this view, describing how teaching with visual arts can help *“make abstract concepts more concrete”* (Wright, 2023, p.155) by helping the child to understand that what they do to an object (e.g apply paint, create a shape, or stick something with glue) has an effect and creates art that is new and different to what they may have seen before.

Additionally, Herzog-Rodriguez (2015) addresses the idea that art therapy aids in the expression of emotion, stating that it can help to ground a child with PMLD through the visceral sensory experience of hitting and shaping clay or fingerpainting. The visual arts can also help to create meaningful interactions between children and their teachers or caregivers. Simmons (2021) describes

“interaction-for-interactions-sake” (p.664) where a child with PMLD can participate in an art activity, leading to engagement with another person which can include physical interactions and emotional expression of laughter. Alongside emotional regulation and expression, the visual arts can *“provide sensory experiences”* (Wallace, 2015, cited by Wright, 2023, p.156) which creates a chance for children with PMLD to express how they feel through alternative ways of communicating. This creates a more flexible way to teach children with PMLD and can aid in a diverse and multi-sensory exploration of the child's thoughts and needs.

In summary, the arts can help to teach children with PMLD and can be used as a way for children to learn that compliments their needs. Disabled children have a right to be taught well and educated in a method that suits them best, and the use of music, theatre and visual arts such as painting is a proven method of allowing these children to unlock their abilities. Dedicated arts services like the therapies discussed are crucial in not only providing a space for these children to learn and feel included in a variety of activities but also to feel accepted, cared for and appreciated for the skills they can develop. While research into the area is still small, developments are continually being made to scope out the true potential arts-based learning can have for children with PMLD. It is clear however, that the arts can contribute to the teaching and learning of these children by creating sessions which allow expression of emotion, alternative forms of communication, meaningful interactions with those who care for them and most importantly self-discovery and self-awareness. This means that the arts can be an empowering and critical method in helping children with PMLD to flourish, grow and learn to their fullest potential.

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